



Ethics and Ethical Theories

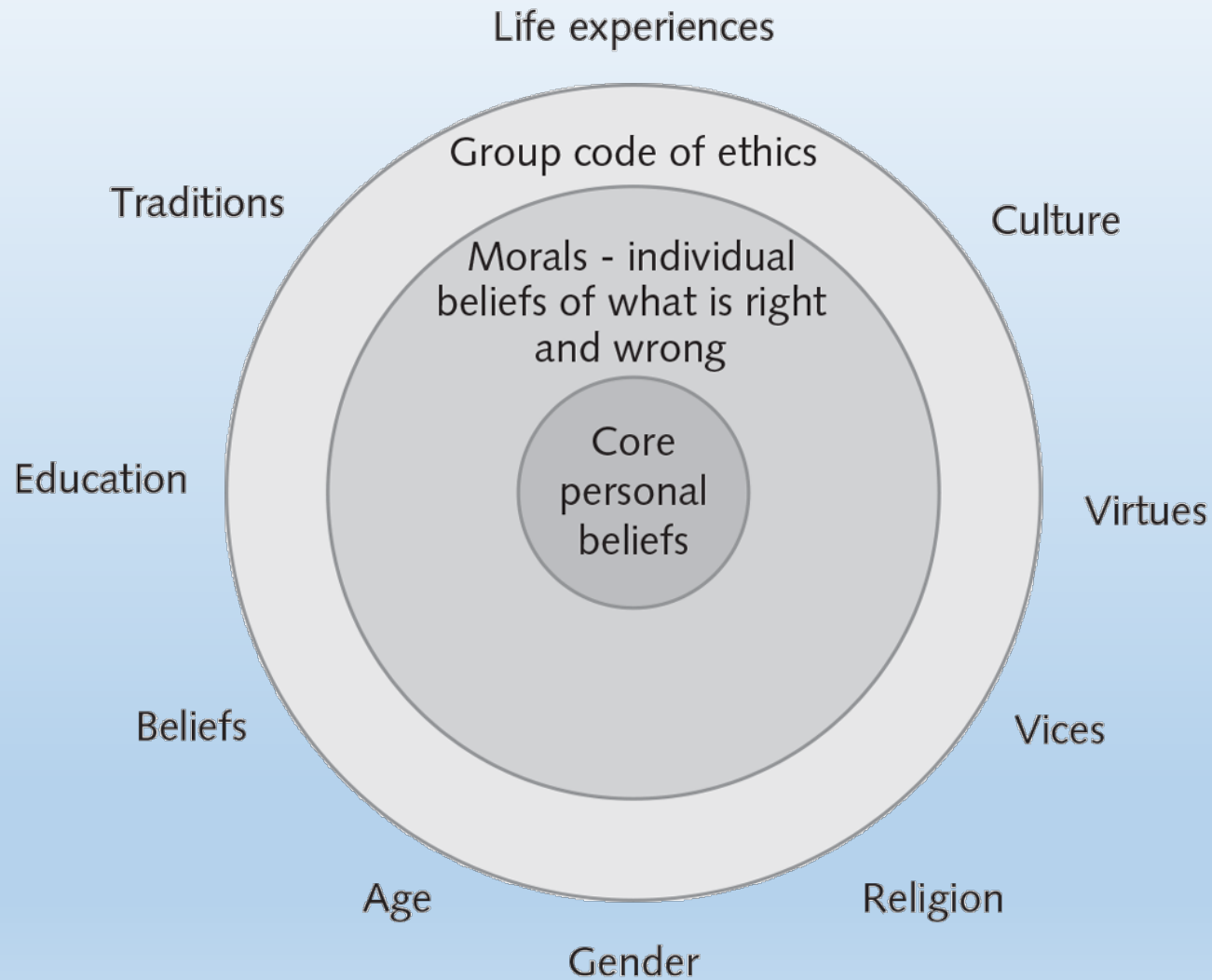


What is Ethics?



- **Ethics:** A code of behavior defined by the group to which an individual belongs
- **Morals:** Personal principles upon which an individual bases his or her decisions about what is right and what is wrong
- **Virtue:** A habit that inclines people to do what is acceptable(Generosity, loyalty)
- **Vice:** A habit of unacceptable behavior(Greed, Envy, anger)

The Relationship Between Ethics and Morals



Difference Between Morals, Ethics, and Laws

Morals	Ethics	Law
• Personal principles an individual uses to determine what is right and what is wrong • Moral acts conform to what an individual believes to be the right thing to do	• Code of behavior that is defined by the group to which an individual belongs	• System of rules, enforced by a set of institutions, that tells us what we can and cannot do • Legal acts are acts that conform to the law



The Ethical Point of View

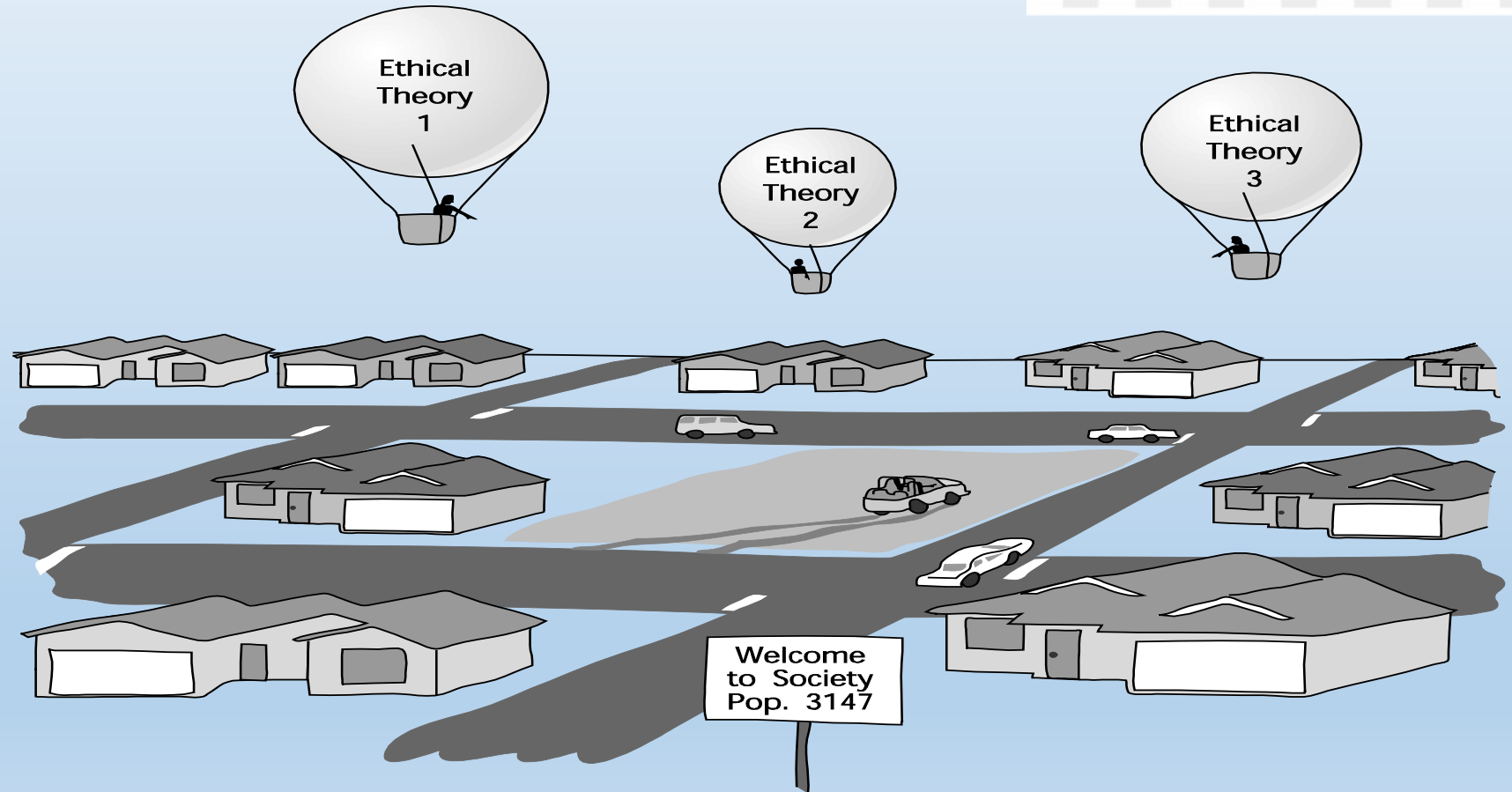
- Everyone shares “core values”, desiring:
 - Life
 - Happiness
 - Ability to accomplish goals
- Two ways to view world
 - **Selfish point of view:** consider only your own self and your core values
 - **Ethical point of view:** respect other people and their core values

Analogy: Difference between Morality and Ethics



An analogy explaining the difference between ethics and morality. Imagine society as a town.

Morality is the road network within the town. People doing ethics are in the balloons floating above the town.



Why Study Ethics?

- **Ethics**: a way to decide the best thing to do
- New problems accompany new technologies
- “Common wisdom” may not exist for situations brought about by new technologies



Definition of Ethics



- In general **Ethics** is the philosophical study of morality, a rational examination into people's moral beliefs and behavior.
- Ethics is a set of moral principles that govern the behavior of an individual or group of people. Computer ethics is the application of moral principles to the use of computers and the Internet.
- Examples include intellectual property rights, privacy policies, and online etiquette, or "netiquette"
- <https://youtube/u399XmkjeXo>

A Good Ethical Theory Enables You to Make Persuasive, Logical Arguments



Ethical Theories



- Subjective Relativism
- Cultural Relativism
- Divine Command Theory
- Ethical egoism
- Kantianism
- Act utilitarianism
- Rule utilitarianism
- Social contract theory
- Virtue ethics

Ethical Egoism:

- Each person should focus exclusively on his or her self-interest
- Morally right action: that action that provides self with maximum long-term benefit

Conclusion: Not a workable ethical theory

Kantianism: (Immanuel Kant)

- Kant believed that people's actions ought to be guided by moral laws, and that these moral laws were universal.
- Our focus should be on what we ought to do. Our sense of "ought to" is called **dutifulness**.
- For Kant, an **imperative** is a way in which reason commands the will.
- There are two kinds of imperatives: hypothetical and categorical, however, only a **categorical imperative** can be a moral imperative.
- **Conclusion: Despite weaknesses, a workable ethical theory**
- <https://youtu.be/-UhiRLuSIIU>



Categorical Imperative (First Formulation)



- you should act only on moral rules that you can imagine everyone else following without deriving a logical contradiction.
- When evaluating a proposed action, reverse roles
- What would you think if that person did the same thing to you?
- If you have a negative reaction → evidence that your will to do that action violates the Categorical Imperative

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- Act so that you treat both yourself and other people as ends in themselves and never only as a means to an end.
- every interaction with other people must give them the dignity and respect they deserve as autonomous, rational beings.
- Kantian analysis of the moral problem focuses on the will behind the action
- The analysis ignores extenuating circumstances that non-Kantians may cite to justify an action

Kant: Wrong to Use Another Person Solely as a Means to an End



- **Act Utilitarianism:** The English philosophers Jeremy Bentham (1748–1832) and John Stuart Mill (1806–1873) proposed a theory that is in sharp contrast to **Kantianism**.



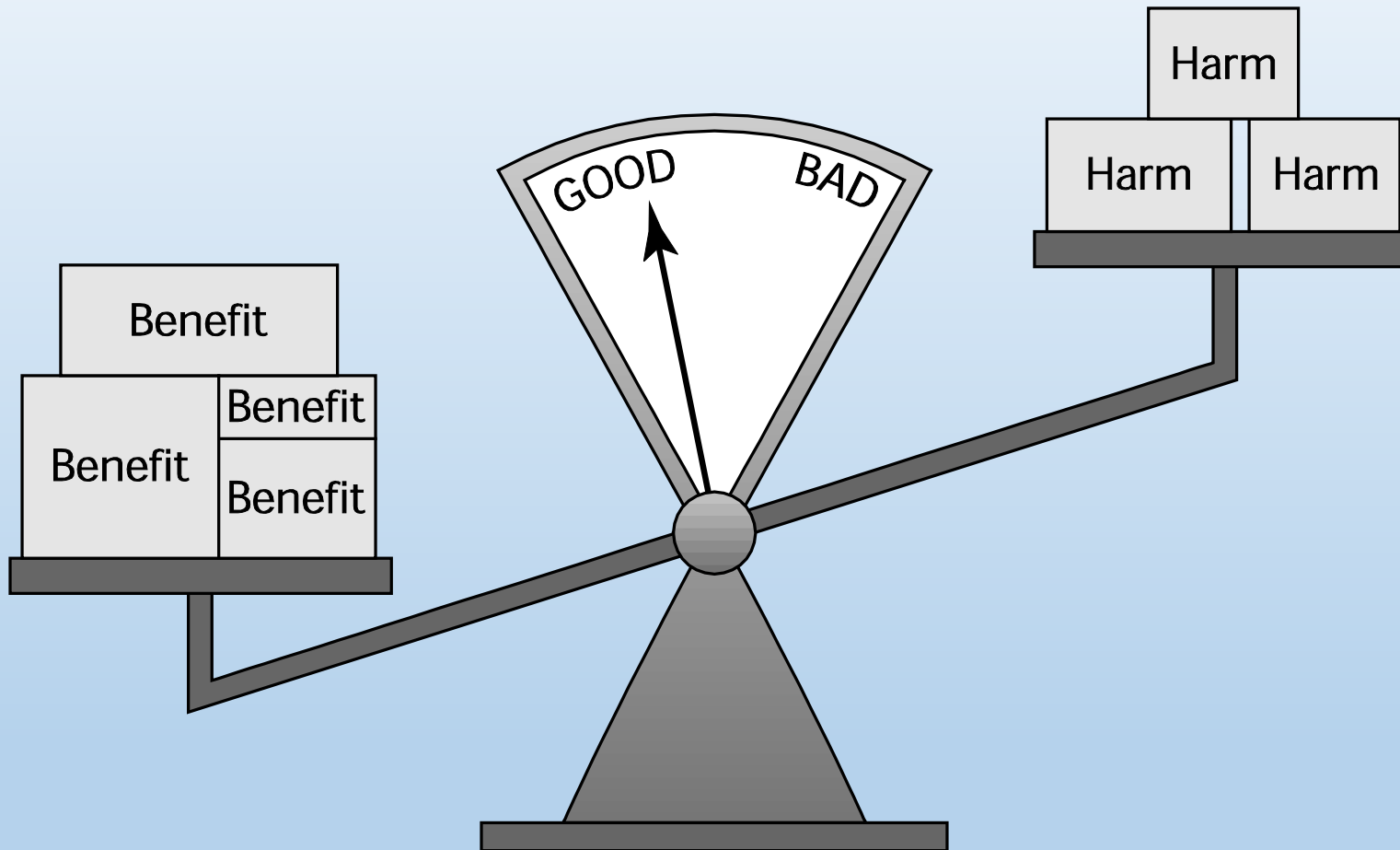
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- An action is good if its benefits exceeds its harms

- ## Conclusion: Overall, a workable ethical theory

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Principle of Utility



Ethics

- ▶ **Subjective Relativism**
- ▶ **Cultural Relativism**
- ▶ **Divine Command Theory**
- ▶ **Ethical egoism**
- ▶ **Kantianism**
- ▶ **Act utilitarianism**
- ▶ **Rule utilitarianism**
- ▶ **Social contract theory**
- ▶ **Virtue ethics**
- ▶ **Comparing workable ethics**
- ▶ **Morality of breaking the**



Rule utilitarianism

Is the ethical theory that holds that we ought to adopt those moral rules that, if followed by everyone, lead to the greatest increase in total happiness over all affected parties.

Conclusion: Despite weaknesses, both act utilitarianism and rule utilitarianism are workable ethical theories

<https://youtu.be/d1R1X9sV9YQ>

Social Contract Theory

Social contract theory says that people live together in society in accordance with an agreement that establishes moral and political rules of behavior.

Hobbes, Locke, and many other philosophers of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries held that all morally significant beings have certain rights, such as the right to life, liberty, and property.

<https://youtu.be/UY3aMtMkoEU>



Rights and Duties



Rights	Explanation
A negative right	is a right that another can guarantee by leaving you alone to exercise your right.
A positive right	is a right that obligates others to do something on your behalf.
An absolute right	is a right that is guaranteed without exception.
A limited right	is a right that may be restricted based on the circumstances

Virtue Ethics



- Virtue ethics is **person rather than action based**: it looks at the virtue or moral character of the person carrying out an action, rather than at ethical duties and rules, or the consequences of particular actions. ... A good person is someone who lives virtuously - who possesses and lives the virtues.(Google)
- A good person does “the right thing at the right time for the right reason”(Virtue Analysis)
- Two types of virtues:
 - intellectual virtues: virtues associated with reasoning and truth
 - moral virtues: virtues of character (a deep seated character trait, e.g., honesty)

Aristotle on Happiness



According to Aristotle, happiness derives from living a life of virtue. You acquire moral virtues by repeating the appropriate acts.



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- Aristotle noticed that in many cases two different vices can be associated with a virtue: one corresponding to an excess and the other corresponding to a deficiency.

<https://youtu.be/qs9QiczZvdU>

Comparing Ethical Theories (Potentially Workable Theories)



Theory	Explanation
Kantianism	Rule-based: Act so that you treat both yourself and other people as ends in themselves and never only as a means to an end. (Categorical imperative)
Act Utilitarianism	Considers the consequences of the action, computing the total change in utility to determine if an action is right or wrong.
Rule Utilitarianism	Rule-based: Considers what the long-term consequences of everyone following the rule would be for the total good.
Social Contract Theory	Rule-based: considers whether rational people would agree to accept the rule, for everyone's mutual benefit, provided that everyone else agreed to follow the rule as well.
Virtue Ethics	Focuses on the agent: Examine the action taken by an agent in a particular situation to determine if that action is characteristic of a virtuous person.

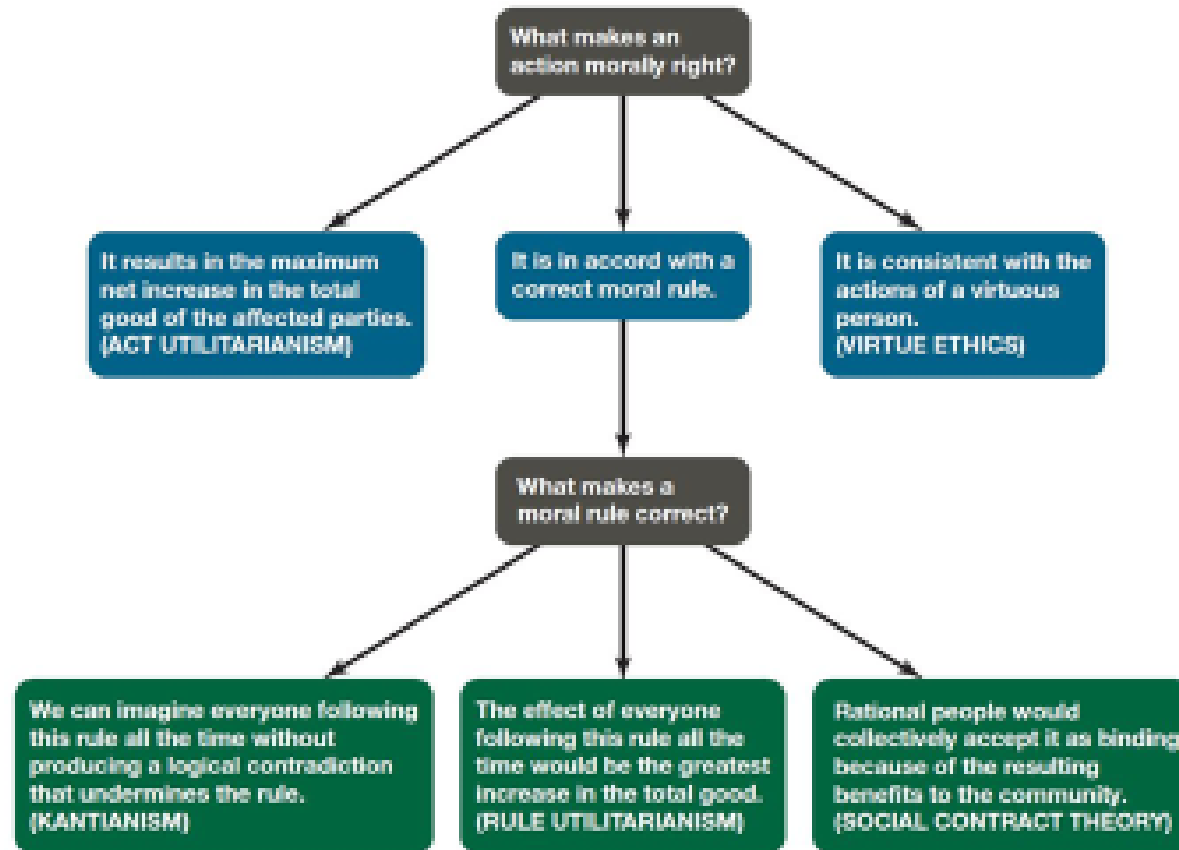
Workable Ethical Theories



Workable ethical theories

- Kantianism
- Act and rule utilitarianism
- Social contract theory
- Virtue ethics

Comparing Workable Ethical Theories







It's up to You

- You **can** consider duties **and** rights **and** consequences **and** virtues when making moral decisions
- Ultimately, you have to decide:
 - What kind of person do I want to be?
 - What kind of world do I want to live in?

